

Thomas Aquinas
Disputed Questions on the Soul in General
(Jeffrey Hause and Claudia Eisen Murphy, translators)

Article 1

Are virtues habits?

Reasons to think they are not, but are acts instead.

1. In his Retractions, Augustine says that virtue is the good use of free choice. But the use of free choice is an act. Therefore, virtue is an act.

2. People are owed reward only on account of their acts. But [a reward] is owed to every virtuous person, since, after all, whoever dies in a state of charity attains happiness. Therefore, virtue is meritorious. Since anything meritorious is an act, virtue is an act.

3. The more God-like something in us is, the better it is. But we are especially like God insofar as we are acting, because God is pure activity. Therefore, the best things in us are acts. But virtues are the greatest goods in us, as Augustine says in his book On Free Choice. Therefore, virtues are acts.

4. The perfection [we can attain on our earthly] journey is parallel to the perfection of the blessed in the heavenly homeland. But the perfection [we find in that] homeland is an act: happiness. Therefore, the perfection [we attain on our earthly] journey— virtue— is also an act.

5. Those things that are classified in the same genus and mutually exclude one another are contraries. But because an act of sin is opposed to virtue, it excludes it. Therefore virtue is in the genus of act.

6. In On the Heavens I, the Philosopher says that virtue is a power's utmost. Since a power's utmost is an act, so is virtue.

7. The rational part [of the soul] is more excellent and more perfect than the sensory part. But the sensory power performs its activity without any mediating habit or quality. Therefore, there is no need to posit in the intellective part any habits by whose mediation the intellective part might perform a perfect activity.

8. The Philosopher says in Physics VII that virtue is a disposition of something perfected to what is best. But since what's best is an act, and since a disposition belongs to the same genus as what it disposes to, it follows that virtue is an act.

9. In On the Customs of the Catholic Church, Augustine says that virtue is the ordering of love. But, as Augustine says in The City of God XIX, an ordering consists in a disposition of equal and unequal things, assigning to each its [proper] place. Therefore, virtue is a disposition, not a habit.

10. A habit is a quality that is difficult to change. But virtue is easy to change, since a single act of mortal sin causes its loss.

11. If we need certain habits—the sort that are virtues--we need them either for natural activities or for meritorious activities, which are, so to speak, supernatural. However, we don't need them for natural activities, because if any nature can perform its activity without a habit — if even sensible and insensible natures can do this, then we have all the more reason to think the rational nature will be able to do it. Likewise, we don't need them for meritorious activities because God performs these in us, “who acts in us to will and to accomplish, because of his good will” (Philippians 2:13). Therefore, [since we need virtues,] virtues are in no way habits.

12. Everything that acts through a form, always acts as that form necessitates. For instance, heat always acts by heating. Therefore, if some habitual form, called a virtue, is in the mind, then it will turn out that anyone with a virtue necessarily acts as the virtue demands. But this is false; for if it were true, every virtuous person would be confirmed [in virtue]. Therefore, virtues are not habits.

13. Habits are in powers to make their activity easier. But clearly, we don't need anything to make our acts of virtue easier [to perform]. For acts of virtue consist principally in choice and volition; and nothing is easier [to perform] than [an act] that consists in a volition. Therefore, virtues are not habits.

14. An effect cannot be more excellent than its cause. But if virtue is a habit, then [a habit] will be the cause of an act, which is more excellent than a habit. Therefore, it appears incorrect to say that virtue is a habit.

15. The mean and the extremes belong to the same genus. But moral virtue is a mean between [extreme] passions, and passions belong to the genus of act. Therefore, [virtue is an act].

Opposing Considerations:

1. According to Augustine, virtue is a good quality of the mind. However, virtue cannot be in any of the species of quality except the first: habit. Therefore, virtues are habits.

2. The Philosopher says in Ethics II that virtue is a habit of choosing, seated in the mind.

3. Those who are asleep [still] have virtue, because virtues are lost only through mortal sin. But there are no virtuous acts in sleepers, because they do not have the use of free choice. Therefore, virtues are not acts.

Reply:

"Virtue," from the very sense of the word, designates what completes a power. That's why virtue is also called strength, since a thing can achieve its proper impulse or movement when its power has been made complete. For "virtue," as the very word implies, refers to a power's perfection. Accordingly, the Philosopher says in On the Heavens I that virtue is the utmost of a power in a thing. However, power is said to be directed to act. Therefore, we see what completes a power when the power undertakes perfect activity. Furthermore, because whatever is active has activity as its end (since everything, according to the Philosopher in On the Heavens I, is for the sake of its activity as its proximate end), each thing is good to the extent that it is fully directed to its end. That's why virtue makes its possessors good and their activity good too, as Ethics II states. What's more, this line [of argument] also makes it clear that virtue is the disposition of something perfected to what is best, as Physics VII states [Metaph.:Phys.].

All these [considerations] apply to whatever virtue you please: a horse's virtue is what makes it and its activity good—and the same is true for the virtue of a stone, or a human being, or anything else.

However, the way a power combines [with a virtue] varies in keeping with the sort of power it is. For one sort of power is only active (1), another is only acted on and moved (2), and a third sort acts and is acted on (3).

(1) A power that is only active does not need anything introduced into it to give rise to its acts. That's why the virtue of such a power is just the power itself. Examples of this sort of power include the divine power, the agent intellect, and natural powers. Hence, the virtues of

these powers are not habits of any kind, but these very powers [which are already] complete in themselves.

(2) On the other hand, those powers that are only acted upon are powers that do not act unless they are moved by others. Their acting or not acting is not up to them; instead, they act through the impulse of the power moving them. The sensory powers, considered in themselves, are of this kind, which is why the Philosopher says in Ethics III that they are not the source of any acts. These powers are perfected for performing their acts by the introduction of something else— something that is in them not in the persistent way forms are in their subjects, but merely in the way an undergoing is. (The species in the eye's pupil is an example of this.) For this reason, the virtues of these powers are not habits either. Instead, they are the powers themselves insofar as they are actually undergoing something due to the causes acting on them.

(3) The powers that are both active and acted upon are those that are moved by what acts on them in such a way that their movers do not determine them to a single [course of action]. Instead, their acting [or not acting] is up to them. To this group belong powers that are rational, [at least] in some measure. These powers are rendered complete for acting by the introduction of something that is in them not merely the way an undergoing is in a subject, but the way a form is: stable and persistent. Even so, the result is not that these forms necessarily compel the power to one [course of action], because if they did, the power would not be in control of its acts. The virtues of these powers are neither the powers themselves, nor undergoings (as with the sensory powers), nor qualities that act necessarily, like the qualities of natural things. Instead, they are habits, through which one can act when one wills to, as the Commentator says in [his long commentary on] On the Soul III. Moreover, Augustine says in On the Good of Marriage that habit is that by which one acts, at the right time.

So, it is clear from these remarks that the virtues [we are concerned with] are habits, and it's also clear how habits, [which constitute the first species of quality], differ from the second and third species. It's readily apparent how they differ from the fourth species, shape: shape, as such, does not imply a directedness to act.

On the basis of these [considerations], I can also show that we need virtuous habits for three reasons.

First, for uniformity in our activity. After all, what depends on activity alone changes easily if it has not been stabilized by a habitual inclination.

Second, we need them to perform a perfect act readily. That's because, unless a habit in some way inclines the rational power to one [sort of activity], then whenever we have to perform an activity, we must always make an inquiry about the activity first. We have a clear example of this in the case of someone who hasn't yet acquired the [relevant] habit of knowledge but wants to reflect, and in the case of someone who lacks the [relevant] habit of virtue, but wants to act as virtue demands. For this reason, the Philosopher says in Ethics V that swift actions are done from habit.

Third, we need virtuous habits to bring our perfect activity to fulfillment pleurably. Habit is responsible for this. Because it has the mode of a nature, it makes the activity proper to it natural, so to speak, and therefore pleurable, since appropriateness causes pleasure. Accordingly, the Philosopher, in Ethics II, holds that pleasure in one's activity is a sign of one's habit.

Responses to the initial arguments:

1. Like power, virtue can also be understood in two ways. In one way, materially, as when we call what we are capable of, our power. It is in this way that Augustine defines virtue as the good use of free choice. In the other way, essentially, and in this way, neither a power nor a virtue is an act.

2. “Meriting” has two senses. (1) In its strict sense, it just means performing some action on the basis of which one justly acquires a reward for oneself. (2) In its looser sense, any condition that makes a human being worthy in any way is called “merit.” For instance, we might say that Priam’s appearance merited a kingdom because it was worthy of a kingdom.

Therefore, since reward is owed to merit, it is owed in a way even to a habitual quality by which someone is made eligible for reward. And in this way a reward is owed to baptized infants. [A reward] is also owed to actual merit, and then it is owed not to virtue itself, but to its act. Still, it’s in a way because of actual merit that [baptized] infants are rewarded too, since the sacrament [of baptism], through which they are born to a new life, gains its effectiveness through Christ’s merit.

3. Augustine says that virtues are the greatest goods of their kinds, not the greatest goods absolutely speaking (just as we say fire is the most refined of bodies). Therefore we cannot conclude that there is nothing in us better than the virtues. We can conclude [only] that they are among those things that are the greatest goods of their kind.

4. Just as in [this] life there is a habitual perfection, which is virtue, and an actual perfection, which is virtue’s act, the same is true in our heavenly homeland. There, happiness is actual perfection, arising from a habit brought to perfection. Accordingly, the Philosopher also says in Ethics I that happiness is an activity in accordance with perfected virtue.

5. An act of vice precludes an act of virtue directly, the way one contrary precludes another. In contrast, it destroys a habit of virtue coincidentally, insofar as it separates a person from God, the cause of infused virtue. That’s why Isaiah says: “your sins divided you from your God” (Isaiah LIX, 2). This also explains why the acquired virtues are not destroyed by a single vicious act.

6. We can understand the Philosopher’s definition in two ways: materially or essentially. If we understand it materially, we are taking “virtue” to mean what a virtue is capable of, which is the utmost among those things a power is capable of. Take, for instance, the virtue of someone who can carry a hundred pounds. This virtue is in him insofar as he is capable of carrying a hundred pounds, not insofar as he is capable of carrying sixty. Alternatively, if we understand it essentially, virtue is called the utmost of a power because it designates what completes the power, whether what completes it is something other than the power or not.

7 As I’ve pointed out, the account of the sensory and the intellective powers are not parallel.

8. That by which something is changed to achieve x, is called a disposition to x. True, the terminus of a change is sometimes in the same genus as the change. For instance, alteration—a kind of change—is a quality, and so a disposition to this terminus always belongs to the same genus as the terminus. Sometimes, however, change and its terminus belong to different genera, as when the terminus of an alteration is a substantial form. So, a disposition does not always belong to the same genus as that to which it is a disposition. For instance, heat [which is a quality] is a disposition to the substantial form of fire.

9. “Disposition” is used in three ways: (1) to mean the disposition through which matter is disposed to receiving form (in this sense, heat is a disposition to [receiving] the form of fire).

(2) to mean the disposition through which an agent is disposed to acting (in this sense swiftness is a disposition for running). (3) to mean the ordering of various things to one another. And it is in that way that Augustine uses “disposition.” But [it’s only when “disposition” is used] in the first sense that disposition is divided in opposition to habit. In the second sense, virtue is itself a disposition.

10. Nothing is so stable that it would not of itself immediately cease to exist if its cause were absent. Therefore, we should not be surprised if one loses infused virtue once mortal sin breaks one’s connection to God. Nor is this incompatible with [infused virtue’s] stability, which can only be understood as [depending] on the continued influence of its cause.

11. We need a habit for each sort of activity. The three reasons given above explain why we need one for natural activities. However, we need a habit for meritorious activity for yet another reason: to raise our natural power to that which is above nature—[which is done] through an infused habit. Nor is this need removed by the fact that God acts in us, because he acts in us in such a way that we are also acting. And so we need a habit to enable us to act sufficiently well.

12. Every form is received in its subject in keeping with the character of the receiver. But it is a characteristic property of a rational power that it is capable of opposed alternatives and that it has control over its own acts. Therefore, it’s never the case that a habitual form compels a rational power [that receives it] to act [always] in the same way. Rather, a rational power [retains the ability] to act or not act.

13. Those acts that consist in choice alone are easy to perform if we don’t take into account the way in which they are performed. But it is not easy to perform them as they should be performed, that is, readily, steadily, and with pleasure. That’s why we need habits of virtue for this.

14. Every animal or human motion that starts afresh comes from some moved mover, and depends on there being some prior act. And so a habit does not elicit an act from itself unless it is being moved by some agent.

15. Virtue is a mean between [contrary] passions, not in the sense that it is itself a mean passion, but because its action brings about the mean between passions.

Article 2

Did Augustine define virtue accurately?

Augustine's definition: "Virtue is a good quality of the mind, by which one lives rightly, which no one uses badly, which God actualizes in us without us."

Reasons to think it is inaccurate:

1. Virtue is a certain goodness. So, if it is itself good, it is so either through its own goodness or through another's. In the second case, we would have an infinite regress. In the first case, virtue would be the primary goodness, because only the primary goodness is good through itself.

2. What is common to every being should not be included in the definition of any one of them. But goodness, which is convertible with being, is common to every being. Therefore, "good" should not be included in the definition of virtue.

3. Goodness plays the same role in the case of natural things that it does in the case of moral [acts and habits]. But, since good and bad do not differentiate species among natural things, we should not include "good" in virtue's definition as the specific differentia of virtue itself.

4. The account of a genus does not include any of its differentiae. However, the account of quality includes "good," just as it also includes "being." Therefore, it should not be added to the definition of virtue so that it reads: "virtue is a good quality of the mind."

5. Goodness and badness are opposites. But badness does not constitute any species, since it is a privation. Therefore, neither does goodness, and so we should not include "good" in the definition of virtue as its constitutive differentia.

6. Since goodness is in more things than quality is, goodness cannot differentiate one quality from another. Therefore, we should not use "good" in virtue's definition as the differentia of quality or of virtue.

7. Nothing is made out of two actualities. But "good" implies an actuality, and so does "quality." Therefore, it's a mistake to say that virtue is a "good quality."

8. What is predicated [of a thing] abstractly is not predicated [of it] concretely. For instance, whiteness is a color, but it is not colored. Since goodness is predicated of virtue abstractly, it is not predicated of it concretely. So, it's not right to say "virtue is a good quality."

9. No differentia is predicated abstractly of a species. That's why Avicenna notes that the human being is not rationality, but rational. Since virtue is a goodness, goodness is not the differentia of virtue. It's not correct to say, then, that "virtue is a good quality."

10. Since what is morally bad is the same as vice, what is morally good is the same as virtue. Therefore, "good" should not be included in the definition of virtue. If it were, [this would be a case of] a thing defining itself.

11. While mind has to do with the intellect, virtue has to do with emotions and desires. It is wrong, then, to say that virtue is "a good quality of the mind."

12. According to Augustine, "mind" refers to the soul's higher part. However, since some virtues are in the soul's lower powers, it's inaccurate to include "good quality of the mind" in virtue's definition.

13. “Subject of virtue” refers to a power, not an essence. But “mind” seems to refer to the soul’s essence, since Augustine says that intelligence, memory and will are all in the mind. Therefore, “mind” should not be included in the definition of virtue.

14. The characteristic property of a species should not be included in its genus’s definition. Since rightness is the characteristic property of justice, [a species of virtue], rightness should not be included in the definition of virtue so as to say [that virtue is] “a good quality of the mind by which one lives rightly.”

15. For living things, existing is living. However, virtue does not perfect us for existing, but for acting. It is incorrect to say, then, that by virtue “one lives rightly.”

16. Whoever is proud of something uses it badly. Since there are people who are proud of their virtues, some people use virtue badly.

17. In On Free choice of the Will, Augustine says that only the greatest goods cannot be used badly. However, virtue is not one of these goods. The greatest goods are the ones we desire for their own sake, but that isn’t true of virtue. We desire virtue for the sake of something other than virtue, since we desire it for the sake of happiness. Accordingly, “which no one uses badly” is wrongly included [in the definition of virtue].

18. A thing is generated, nourished and grows from the same [source]. But virtue is nourished and grows by our own acts, since a decrease in cupidity is an increase in charity. Therefore, virtue is generated by our acts. The clause “which God actualizes in us without us,” then, is wrongly included in the definition.

19. We count what removes an impediment as a mover and a cause. Since free choice in a way removes impediments to virtue, it is in a way virtue’s cause. Therefore, the claim that God actualizes virtue without us is wrongly included in the definition.

20. Augustine says “he that created you without you will not justify you without you.” Therefore, [the clause “that God actualizes in us without us,” is wrongly included in the definition].

21. It’s obvious that this definition applies to grace. Since grace and virtue are not one and the same thing, the definition does not define virtue correctly.

Reply:

This formulation captures the definition of virtue, even if we leave out the last clause; and in fact it is accurate for every human virtue.

As I have said [in a.1 Reply], virtue perfects a power for producing a perfect act. Moreover, because a perfect act is the end of the power or the agent [producing it], virtue makes both the power and the agent good, as I noted earlier. Accordingly, the definition of virtue includes something about the act’s perfection, and something about the perfection of the power or agent.

Two things are required for an act’s perfection: (1) the act must be right, and (2) the habit [from which it springs] must be incapable of being the source of a contrary act. That’s because a source of [both] good and bad acts cannot, in its own nature, be a perfect source of a good act. Because a habit is a power’s perfection, [if one’s act is to be perfect], the habit must be the source of a good act in such a way that it cannot be the source of a bad one. That’s why the Philosopher says in Ethics VI that opinion, which can be true or false, is not a virtue; whereas knowledge, which we have only of true things, is a virtue. The first [requirement for a perfect act] is captured by the clause “by which one lives rightly,” and the second by the clause “which no one uses badly.”

Virtue also makes its subject good. In connection with this function, we must consider three things: (1) The subject itself. This is specified by the expression “of the mind,” since human virtue can be only in what belongs to a human being as such. (2) The intellect’s perfection is designated by [Augustine’s] inclusion of “good,” since something is called good because of its directedness to its end. (3) Finally, “quality” designates the way it inheres in its subject, because virtues are not in their subject the way passions are, but the way habits are, as I pointed out above.

All these elements apply to moral, intellectual and theological virtues, regardless of whether the virtues are acquired or infused. But the clause Augustine adds [to these]—“which God actualizes in us without us”—applies only to infused virtues.

Responses to the initial arguments:

1. Just as accidents are called beings not because they subsist, but because by them something is [in a certain respect], so virtue is called good not because it is itself good, but because through it something is good. So, it’s not necessary that virtue be good through another goodness, as if it were informed by another goodness.

2. It is not the goodness that is convertible with being that is included here in the definition of virtue, but rather the goodness that is specific to moral acts.

3. Actions are differentiated on the basis of the agent’s form ([as we see,] for instance, [with] heating and cooling). Now, goodness and badness are like the will’s form and object, since what is active always impresses its form on what is passive, and the mover on what it moves. That’s why moral acts, whose source is the will, are differentiated into species on the basis of goodness and badness. On the other hand, the source of natural activities is the form and not the end. That explains why, among natural things, species are not differentiated on the basis of goodness and badness, though among moral [acts and habits] they are.

4. Moral goodness is not included in the concept of quality, so the argument is irrelevant.

5. Badness does not constitute a species in virtue of being a privation, but in virtue of what underlies the privation, since that is incompatible with the character of goodness. This explains how [badness] can constitute a species.

6. This objection assumes [“goodness” has the sense of] “natural goodness rather than the sense of “moral goodness”—the sense found in the definition of virtue.

7. “Goodness” [in Augustine’s definition] does not imply any goodness other than virtue itself. This is clear from what I’ve said [in the response to the first argument], since virtue is essentially a quality. It’s clear, then, that “good” and “quality” do not refer to different actualities, but to one and the same.

8. This [argument] does not work in the case of transcendentals, which encompass every being; after all, essence is a being, goodness is good, and oneness is one, though we cannot say on the same pattern that whiteness is white. Here is the reason: whatever the intellect can grasp, it must grasp as falling under the character of being and, consequently, under the character of good and of one. That’s why the intellect can grasp essence, and goodness, and oneness only under the character of good, of one, and of being. It’s for this reason that we can say that goodness is good, and oneness is one.

[The manuscripts do not contain any responses by Aquinas to initial arguments 9-21.]